halting military hostilities, prevented the entry of great powers in that conflict.[21] Having secured assurance of continuing protection under the treaty, India's success in the conflict demonstrated New Delhi's ability to manipulate power politics to increase its regional clout. This push to build security in its immediate neighbourhood without the interference of external powers became a central component of India's diplomatic efforts after the success of the 1971 war.

Closer ties with the Soviet Union also ensured a reliable supplier for defence equipment. There is marked continuity in this aspect of the relationship, which was sustained through leadership changes and periods of warmer and cooler relations. Adding to the continuity of Indo–Soviet relations throughout the Cold War were other measures of collaboration, including Soviet support for India's economic plans, favourable oil prices, the launch of two satellites for India, generous loan rates, and a willingness to accept goods in exchange for military equipment.[22]

Yet even at the zenith of relations with the Soviet Union, India retained space for leverage by reaching out to the West. By the 1980s, this initiative was accompanied by an improvement in political relations. This improvement was partially a result of Ronald Reagan's efforts to bridge the divide between the United States and India as part of a broader strategy to undercut Soviet influence. But there was also a growing overlap of interests. Although Rajiv Gandhi's ability to shift away from Soviet dependency was limited, the United States welcomed his more liberal economic policies. In addition, there were elements of agreement regarding Pakistan, especially following the Soviet withdrawal from Afghanistan and growing concerns over its move to acquire nuclear weapons capability. The Indo–US relationship remained tenuous through to the end of the Cold War, owing to lingering suspicions of loyalties and